

small border as she feels it makes her look a little taller. But there is no frenzied speculation—or criticism—about her wardrobe. As Malvika points out, “Gursharanji is at a different age, she cannot play the teeny bopper. However, she showcases the best of India. She represents simple elegance.”

Yet, Gursharan has had to carefully construct an image at par with the Carlas and the Michelles. An occasional matching handbag and overcoat are recent additions to her style sheet. Moreover, it is not always her own image that she is worried about. Former media advisor in the PMO Sanjaya Baru recalls that what riled her most was when the media flipped a picture of Manmohan during printing so that his turban showed up tied from left to right instead of the other way round. She also gets upset with negative media coverage. As she tells her daughters, he works so hard (“*jee jaan se*”) that it’s unfair.

In the West, first ladies have a structured role to which they bring their distinctive style and agenda, but not so in India where they are a rarity rather than the rule. Jawaharlal Nehru, a widower, had his daughter Indira step in as his hostess. The wives of V.P. Singh, Chandra Shekhar and H.D. Deve Gowda remained in the background or, as in Gowda’s case, only surfacing for his foreign sojourns. Vajpayee, a bachelor, never had a hostess by his side. Gursharan, on the other hand, has redefined the parameters. Before the Singhs shifted into Race Course Road there was media speculation that the move was delayed because the kitchen slabs were being lowered to suit Gursharan’s height. But while she still makes the occasional cup of tea for her husband and is always there when he comes home for lunch, her world has clearly ventured much beyond the kitchen sink. She is now a woman with a cause, creating awareness about child labour, breast cancer and street children. She also launches books, winter carnivals and

FIRST Circle

HER STYLE

A BA in Music, she used to sing on Jalandhar radio before her marriage in 1958. Still sings the Gurbani at private dos. Prefers salwar kameez but now wears silk saris and pearls.



HER DAUGHTERS

The oldest, Upinder, teaches history at Delhi University. The shy Daman works in rural development. The father’s favourite, Amrit, is a civil rights activist who took on the Bush administration. All three have written books.



HER FRIENDS

A close Lutyen’s Delhi circuit. Has coffee with Khushwant Singh, drags social worker Rita Devi Varma to plays. Her favourite hosts are Isher Ahluwalia, Harjeet Charanjit Singh and Malvika Singh.



khadi pavilions at trade fairs and dances with Sheila Dikshit and Preity Zinta on International Women’s Day.

There’s no denying that the prime minister’s wife has brought a certain zest to the office. During a recent TV interview she wished that there was a defined role for the spouse so that she could do more for the people. Unfortunately, doing too much can sometimes be misinterpreted. “She attends charity events. She doesn’t come to buy but to meet the artisans and acknowledge their work. She is not there to show off but to encourage,” says a friend. In fact, though Malvika had invited her for her own book launch, it was not as the chief guest as she did not expect her to attend. But Gursharan did come. When asked to join chief guest Dikshit on the dais, she refused saying she had come merely as a friend.

Having a first lady in attendance has added another dimension to the PMO. During the G-20 meet she accompanied the first ladies to a briefing by the World Food Organisation. With former Pakistan president General Pervez Musharraf’s mother she used good old fashioned *saas-bahu* diplomacy to charm the old lady, saying, “I envy your daughter-in-law, she has a mother-in-law like you.” A delighted Manmohan repeated this conversation to an amused Musharraf later.

Her homilies complement the prime minister’s studied seriousness. Together they bring an old world grace and charm to the PMO’s “room-service” brand of hospitality. This was on display on Children’s Day recently when the Singhs played gracious host to a group of enthusiastic school children. He gave them career advice while she ensured they had enough to eat. And when he began to quote his favourite Mirza Ghalib couplet, it was she who finished it for him. Clearly, her BA in Music has been finetuned to accompany his academic prowess.

The Doctor Saheb-and-Gursharanji partnership works wonders as India’s First Couple—not just in poetry. ■